

Sentinels of the Dawn

Poor Clares Perpetual Adoration
Our Lady of the Angels Monastery
Troyes

Christmas 2018 Issue 22

And the Word was made flesh and dwelt among us...

When our Bishop, the Most Reverend Marc Stenger, officially designated our Chapel as the Eucharistic Sanctuary of the Diocese of Troyes in June of 2017, our hearts filled with thanksgiving for the wonderful mission he had entrusted to us. At Mother Marie Emmanuel's request, he appointed a team to work with us on a diocesan level: the Most Reverend Yves Patenôtre, Father Jean-Marc Grand, and Father Laurent Thibord. With prayer and reflection, the team began to formulate how to develop the Sanctuary.

The first step seemed to be to extend the hours that the Sanctuary was open. Over the years, more and more people were already coming during the daytime from 8am to noon, and from 2pm to 6pm for a time of silent prayer before the Blessed Sacrament solemnly exposed. At these hours the Sisters have always assured and continue to assure Adoration in the cloistered side of the Chapel. In order to leave the Chapel open for prayer from 8am to 8pm, the team decided to appeal to the parishioners in the central part of the city where our Monastery is located. Mr. Arnould de Ravinel generously took on the organization of this appeal to cover the hours when the Chapel had previously been closed. The results were marvelous. Thanks to the fidelity of those who have committed themselves to a weekly hour of Adoration, the Eucharistic Sanctuary has been open to all from 8 am until 8pm every day for a time of silent prayer before Jesus truly present in the Most Blessed Sacrament



This past Lent, Mother Marie Emmanuel asked our little community of nine Sisters to consider increasing our nocturnal adoration from one night to four nights a week. Without any hesitation, the Sisters said "yes" and by the time Easter arrived they added an "alleluia" to a "yes, we want to continue four nights a week." Then came the possibility of offering night adoration to those who wished to commit themselves to a weekly hour of Adoration between 8pm Thursday and 8am Friday. Announcements appeared in the city's parish bulletins thanks to the support and encouragement of their pastors with an invitation to come for Vespers on Sunday, November 11th. A short meeting followed in the Monastery Parlor, led by Fr. Thibord and Mr. de Ravinel. We quickly had 12 volunteers who committed themselves to a six-week trial period of one hour of night Adoration. As word spread of this possibility, more people signed up; there are now 24 night adorers! While the world around us slumbers, a handful of « sentinels » keeps watch with Jesus, praying for the needs of the Church and the world. In January, we will see how the Holy Spirit inspires the next step.

What is most important is to let these hours of Adoration bear fruit in our lives. We have the gift of celebrating the Eucharist, we have the beautiful practice of adoring Christ in the Eucharist, but He calls us to daily Eucharistic living. For this reason, one Sunday evening a month at Vespers, Archbishop Patenôtre gives a brief teaching as a means of deepening our desire not only to pray before the Blessed Sacrament but to live the Eucharistic Mystery in our daily lives. What we have been given as a grace, we are called to share.

The following are testimonies from persons who come to our Chapel for Eucharistic Adoration:

A few years ago in another city, my wife and I had signed up for Adoration on Sunday evening from 8pm to 9pm. Once I was a little more tired than usual, I fell asleep before Jesus-hostie. When I woke up, I was ashamed of not being able to watch for an hour. Then I heard in the depth of my heart the voice of Christ who simply said to me: "While you were sleeping, I was contemplating you". In the verb ontemplate, I felt all the love He had for me. Adoration is not only about us spending time with Christ, but it is also a moment when we stand before Him as we are and allow Him to pour His love on us. Thank you to the Poor Clares for giving us the opportunity to adore Jesus. - Bertrand

I signed up for an hour of Adoration each week. Sometimes I come with my worries and small problems...and even if I feel unworthy with all of my preoccupations of the world today, I tell myself that even if only one person who was passing by would spend only five minutes before the Blessed Sacrament, the world would be so different. No matter what troubles I might be experiencing at the moment, I receive an indescribable peace in the midst of this troubled world. I return home bringing Christ with me. –Joëlle

A Tribute to Sister Marie of the Presentation

It was due to the interest that Mr. Jésus Cervantes, Mayor of La Villeneuve-au-Chêne had for one of our deceased Sisters which led us to celebrate the 70th anniversary of the transfer of the body of our sister Marie de la Presentation, from the cemetery of the above mentioned village to that of Troyes. Indeed, Mr. Cervantes wanted to know who this sister was that had been temporarily buried in his village in 1940. Thanks to the research of Mr. Pierre-Eugène Leroy, historian and friend of our community, as well as the assistance of our sister Marie-Antoinette, archivist, Mr. Cervantes discovered a personality that greatly touched him. He wanted to pay tribute to her, making her a little more well known.



On Sunday, November 4th, the Most Reverend Msgr. Yves Patenôtre, Archbishop Emeritus of the Diocese of Sens-Auxerre presided at the solemn Mass which was followed by a short time of prayer at the Troyes cemetery before the Sisters' common tomb. At 3pm, he led a prayer service at the Church of Saint Nicolas in La Villeneuve-au-Chene. Mr. Leroy read the story of her death, while Sister Mary Antoinette played a beautiful musical accompaniment on the violin. A reception followed, prepared by the Mayor and his wife, for all participants who attended the event, which brought an end to the beautiful day.

But who is Sr. Marie of the Presentation? Joan Nys 1905-1940) Born into a strong Catholic family on February 14, 1905, she was baptized April 23 and given the beautiful name of Joan.

In her relations with family and friends she was known to have a sensitive, vibrating, radiant heart; in the spiritual life, her soul seemed to soar to the heights and lose itself in prayer. Despite the resistance of her family, at the age of 22, she entered the monastery, stating: "God is to be served first and above all."

On May 23, 1928 she received the holy Franciscan habit and her new name: Sr Marie of la Presentation. Because of her lively and joyful temperament, one of the older Sisters in the Community would later tell her: *We were mistaken in choosing your name, we should have called you Sr. Mary of Holy Enthusiasm!*

She loved everything about monastic life, and her duties in the Monastery were librarian and making sacred linen. It was noted that she said, "Here in the Monastery every day is like Corpus Christi."

But, on September 1st, 1939 the general mobilization was decreed. She increased her prayers and sacrifices for her loved ones, especially for her brother and the priests who were close friends of the monastery who were also mobilized, as well as for the protection of the Polish Sisters of our Order.

June 12th and 13th, 1940 Troyes was bombed. Early in the morning of the 14th, the Sisters, like many others, left in exodus. A freight train stopped nearby and they got on the cattle carriages with other people. At 12:30, when the train stopped at La Villeneuve-au-Chêne, it was targeted by an airplane, and Sr Marie of the Presentation was fatally wounded. She is transported to a nearby factory, close to the train station. At 3:30 pm, after offering her great sufferings for her Order for France, for souls, she surrenders her soul to God. A small cabinet served as her coffin and her body was temporarily buried in a garden.

The remaining Sisters of the Community were able to return to the Monastery on June 24, and on August 18, an Extern Sister was driven to La Villeneuve-au-Chene where she found the place where Sister was temporarily buried. Her body was exhumed. The wood of the cabinet was rotten, the sheet that enveloped her body was covered with mold, but her remains were intact, very beautiful. A grave was dug for her at the village cemetery. It was there that she rested until November 4, 1948, when her body was transferred to the cemetery of Troyes and placed in the Sisters vault.

"I desire to be the mother of many souls, especially the souls of priests. " One of Sister Marie of the Presentation's last prayer intentions.intentions.



From left to right: Mr. Jésus Cervantes, Mother Marie Emmanuel, Mr. Leroy, and Sister Mary Antoinette. (Photo credit: l'Est-Eclair, local newspaper in Troyes)

The plaque in honor of Sister Marie of the Presentation on the altar at St. Nicholas Church.





L to R: Mr. Jésus Cervantes, Sister M. Antointte, Mother M. Emmanuel and Archbishop Yves Patenôtre at St. Nicholas Church.

A time for tearing down and a time for rebuilding

With the arrival of winter, the Sisters are especially grateful for their newly renovated cells (monastic term for bedroom) that have double-paned windows, properly insulated walls and heat. Our new library is also coming to life. Sister Claire-Myriam, who was assigned this charge, has patiently sorted through the mountain of boxes containing books and arranged them on the shelves. She will soon begin the long process of classifying each volume. Sister Mary Antoinette is also working on gradually transferring the precious archives of our Order into their newly designated area. Once again, we express our deep gratitude to the Foundation of Monasteries and all of our benefactors whose generosity made this renovation possible.



As you know, we have a special attachment to our Troyes Monastery because it was the first foundation of our Order. The oldest wing dates from the 16th century and that's where we spend a lot of time in our unheated, poorly equipped kitchen. We also have our laundry on that side of the Monastery which still has a large, old stone washing basin like you see in the famous picture of St Therese of Lisieux washing clothes with her Sisters! We really need a kitchen with sufficient work space for a community of nine Sisters, all of whom don their aprons daily to prepare meals and afterwards wash and dry the dishes. In the summer time, we all work there together to conserve the harvest of our vegetable garden, to make jelly, and later in the season apple juice, and lots of cookies for our Christmas sale and gifts! We are certainly not looking for a "Better Homes and Garden" type kitchen or laundry; but we need work spaces that are functional, clean, and economic to run. Would you be willing to help us once again with even a small donation and with you prayers?



A time set apart for God

Our annual Community retreat took place in September. Father Bernard, a Benedictine monk of the Abbey of Notre Dame de Maylis graciously accepted our invitation to be the retreat master. His conferences focused on prayer which is the heart of our lives as cloistered religious and our spiritual journey with God. We were grateful for this sacred time set apart to listen to God speak to our hearts through His Word and through Father's prayerful reflections.



Our two younger Indian Sisters, Sister Antonine Marie and Sister Martino Marie, have been with our Community for a little more than a year. They have been diligently studying the French language and have made a lot of progress but Mother Emmanuel thought it would be best if their annual retreat could be in English. She contacted the MEP's in Paris (Missionaries of Foreign Countries) and much to her surprise, she discovered that the Superior of the Community, Father Balthazar, was from Bangalore, India! Father arrived on November 2nd.



Using several different biblical figures from the Old Testament as models, Father's retreat focused on our particular mission as contemplatives and the faith that is needed to live it. On Father's last day at the Monastery, he met with the entire Community for a few hours in the afternoon to share his own vocation story and his mission in France. His words were very encouraging and filled us with renewed zeal for our particular mission here in Troyes. May the Lord bless Fr. Bernard and Fr. Baltazar for the spiritual renewal they offered us during our time set apart for God. May the fruit that we have received help us to grow in our union with Christ and be ever more generous in our service to His Church.

En September our Bishop, the Most Reverend Marc Stenger surprised us by coming to celebrate the Holy Mass in our Chapel. Afterwards, the Sisters spoke with him for a short time. Despite the fact that his schedule is very full and he travels a lot, he always seems to find time to pay us a visit a few times a year. We are very grateful to him for his goodness to our Community, for his words of encouragement and his support. His zeal for the Church and for souls inspires us in our own vocation. We pray that God may continue to bless him in his ministry and grant him the graces that he needs to shepherd the flock entrusted to his loving care.





A few days before the Solemnity of All Saints, a dear friend and benefactor of our Community, Mr. Michael Schall, presented us with a wonderful gift. He prepared and installed a beautiful wooden border around the flower gardens that are found near the tomb of our beloved foundress, Mother Marie of Sainte Claire. It really adds a certain beauty to this special, sacred place which is often visted by our Sisters who wish to pray to their spiritual mother.

Mr. Schall's generosity is without end, as he also often brings us fresh-cut flowers so that our Sister Sacristan can prepare bouquets to be placed on each side of the Blessed Sacrament in our Chapel.

May God reward Mr. Schall and his family for their goodness to us and for great desire to assist us in our needs.

MONASTERE DES CLARISSES
26 RUE MITANTIER
10000 TROYES, FRANCE



To help us save money on postage, paper and ink, we would like to propose sending you our newsletter by email. Would you please consider sending us your email address to:

secretariat.clarissesdetroyes@gmail.com

May the Christmas season be a time of peace and joy for you. May the Infant Jesus illumine your path with His Light, so that you may in turn share this light and life with others. May the Lord bless you with abundant graces throughout 2019! You and your intentions will be remembered in our prayers before the Most Blessed Sacrament.

The Poor Clares of Troyes, France wish
you and your loved ones
a Merry Christmas and
a Happy and Holy New Year!

